



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Rochester Classical Academy
School Website: <https://rochesterclassicalacademy.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Rochester Classical Academy (RCA) presents a clearly classical, Christian model of education. Public materials from RCA articulate a mission of forming godly character and a joyful spirit of inquiry into God and His creation, with education designed to engage the world for Christ through wisdom, virtue, and eloquence. The school foregrounds classical elements—grammar, logic, rhetoric; the study of Great Books; liberal-arts formation; and a pedagogy that blends contemplative/Scholastic rhythms with Socratic-style discussion and rhetoric-rich upper grades. The faculty pages highlight model teachers who embody and live the curriculum, while parental partnership and community involvement are repeatedly emphasized (tours, open admissions processes, and parent involvement). Taken together, RCA aligns strongly with the six elements of classical education in the knowledge base and the school's own materials.

Key evidence includes RCA's mission statement tying character formation to a spirit of inquiry into God, explicit articulation of biblical truth across subjects, a curriculum rooted in grammar/logic/rhetoric and Great Books, and pedagogy that alternates contemplative/recitation memory work with Socratic dialogue and rhetorical training. The site also emphasizes a living curriculum through its faculty, and a parental partnership model that treats parents as co-teachers in a faith-based classical program. In short, RCA demonstrates broad-based alignment with classical education across all six categories, with a particularly strong match in religious foundations, curriculum, pedagogy, and the formation of a living, intergenerational learning community.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- **Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations** — CLASSICAL Evidence includes a mission centered on cultivating godly character and a spirit of inquiry into God, explicit references to biblical truth and Christ-centered formation, and a Statement of Faith tied to a Christian framework. Positive indicators such as "godly character," "spirit of inquiry into God," and biblical truth are plentiful in RCA's materials; these reinforce transcendental moral realism and a theology-infused approach. RCA frequently grounds education in a Christian worldview (e.g., "classical Christian tradition," "biblical truth"). See mission statements and faith materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: God, godly character, Christ, biblical truth, theology, creation, Imago Dei, worship/holy, wisdom, virtue.
 - Negative keywords: not evidenced in RCA materials (the provided corpus does not reveal relativism or secular humanism as a prominent frame). Why this rating: The school's public materials embed a Christian metaphysical framework, with explicit references to God, biblical truth, and a Statement of Faith; this strongly supports Classical alignment in foundational belief and liturgical/community life. The period emphasizes transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a theologically grounded formation.
- **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal** — CLASSICAL Evidence includes language about forming virtue and wisdom, human flourishing through liberal education, and pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty as real. The mission emphasizes formation over mere information, with explicit aim for lifelong inquiry

beyond graduation. The school frames education as training in virtue and wisdom rather than job-readiness alone; the motto includes “truth, goodness, and beauty” as real and knowable. See mission statements and philosophy statements.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: formation, virtue, wisdom, true/good/beautiful (via Phil 4:8 framing), liberal education, scholé (contemplation/rest), great conversation, human excellence, soul craft.
 - Negative keywords: workforce preparation emphasis and “21st-century skills” are not foregrounded in RCA’s own materials. Why this rating: RCA’s stated purpose centers on virtue, wisdom, human excellence, and contemplation, with lifelong formation in view, aligning strongly with classical aims rather than utilitarian job-prep phrasing.
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit emphasis on liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), a Great Books orientation (readings and “Great Books” as core), and the aim to study history across the curriculum (not just as social studies). The materials describe studying classics (Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, CS Lewis’s works), Latin/Greek, and history in a classical framework; there is direct mention of “tools of learning” and “the Great Conversation.” See “Academics Overview” and “The Tools for a Life of Learning.”

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Homer/Plato/Augustine/Shakespeare, Latin, Greek, history/Western civilization, narration, recitation, dictation, hymnody, sacred art.
 - Negative keywords: indications of project-based learning or social-studies-as-history reframing are not evident; the site emphasizes history as a component of Western civilization rather than “social studies” as a modern framing. Why this rating: RCA’s curriculum is clearly anchored in classical content and methods—grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, classical languages, and history as a liberal-arts core—matching the canonical classical model.
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL Evidence includes lower-school practices (memory work, chanting, singing to reinforce memory) and upper-school Socratic discussion, with rhetoric training, oratory and debate, and opportunities for students to present speeches. There is explicit language about contemplative/Scholé rhythms and a balance between restful learning and rigorous study. The “Tools for a Life of Learning” document (present in the knowledge corpus) outlines the continuum from grammar to logic to rhetoric, with memory work, recitation, and disciplined practice, and it discusses Socratic/seminar-style work in high school.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: Socratic seminar, questioning, dialectic, disputation, narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize, memory work, liturgical calendar integration, seminars, rhetoric exercises, speech, declamation, oratory, debate, restfulness/scholé, contemplation/wonder, upper-school rhetoric theses, capstone orations.
 - Negative keywords: experiential learning focus, project-based only, student-directed/constructivist approaches are not described as primary methods; the explicit balance between contemplative and rigorous pedagogy is presented as intentional. (The lexicon lists potential negative signals; RCA’s materials do not foreground these negative signals.) Why this rating: RCA explicitly couples contemplative, memory-based pedagogy in the early grades with Socratic discussion and rhetoric in later grades, aligning with classical pedagogy norms and indicating a CLASSICAL teaching approach.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit statements that faculty are model teachers and mentors who embody virtue and knowledge; the living curriculum is described as the core of the school; teachers are portrayed as collegial mentors and “living curriculum.” The faculty pages detail leadership (Head of School) and teachers with personal faith and long-term commitments to classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplars, portrait of what a teacher should be, lifelong learners, great books seminars for faculty.
 - Negative keywords: none evidenced in RCA materials. Why this rating: RCA presents a coherent staff culture described as exemplars and living curriculum, with a strong sense of mentorship and shared mission, which aligns with classical expectations for faculty.
- Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL Evidence includes a strong emphasis on partnership with parents, parent formation opportunities (book studies, gatherings), and open-campus/visits. RCA invites parental involvement through tours, admissions processes designed to inform prospective families about classical Christian education, and opportunities for family participation in school life. The admissions and “Connect with RCA” pages show open engagement with families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis:

- Positive keywords detected: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, hospitality, parent covenant, family involvement, visits welcomed.
- Negative keywords: none indicated; RCA's materials emphasize parental involvement rather than consumer-centric language. Why this rating: RCA's communications repeatedly frame parents as co-teachers and active participants in a classical educational community, matching the classical model's expectation of robust parent-community partnership.

Overall aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

Rochester Classical Academy demonstrates strong alignment with classical education across all six categories. The school's public materials present a robust religious/metaphysical foundation, a formation-focused purpose, a curriculum rooted in grammar/logic/rhetoric and the Great Books, a pedagogy combining Schola/restful learning with Socratic and rhetorical training, a faculty described as living exemplars and mentors, and a parent-community partnership that positions families as co-educators. The presence of explicit Christian faith commitments (including a Statement of Faith) and a mission to form character and wisdom further anchors RCA in the classical Christian tradition.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. No category requires needle-moving changes to reach CLASSICAL status; RCA already aligns with the classical model across the six dimensions.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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